

The Anchors and the Blasters: A Cricketing Lesson in Thematic Hybrid Portfolios

Markets, like cricket, reward those who know when to attack and when to defend.

In the scorching summer of 2026, the Indian Premier League was in full swing, with two distinct batting styles colliding. On one hand, there was Virat Kohli who played with a straight bat face, high elbows, and an intensely focused gaze. He batted like a monk, rotating the strike, absorbing pressure, and slowly building towards a substantial score. On the other hand, there was the young and explosive Vaibhav Suryavanshi, who burst onto the scene with audacious pulls and scoops, lofted drives, and sixes that lit up the stadium.

Similarly, in the volatile world of Indian investing in the mid-2020s, domestic investors have been facing a series of shocks. Trade tariffs have spun out of control, geopolitical tensions have escalated, energy prices have spiked, supply chains have come under pressure, and AI-induced disruptions have become the norm. The markets have swung wildly. However, just like the Sensex, which climbed to 85,000 over two decades before correcting itself, equities have a way of weathering the storm.

Debt, on the other hand, plays a steadier role, offering consistent returns of around 7–8% over the long haul, as seen in benchmarks like the CRISIL Composite Bond Index. Its true value lies in cushioning falls and providing liquidity to seize opportunities when the market faces stress.

This is where the thematic hybrid portfolio comes in. In this portfolio, aggressive thematic equities take on the role of Vaibhav Suryavanshi, providing explosive exposure to sectors aligned with macro tailwinds, such as technology, renewables, infrastructure, or consumption recovery. These are the “Kaboom” elements, selected after rigorous scrutiny of fundamentals, global cycles, interest rates, inflation, valuations, and currency flows.

However, no sensible investor would put all their eggs in one basket. That’s where the debt component comes in — carefully chosen fixed-income instruments that hold the other end with Kohli-like discipline. It limits drawdowns during equity collapses and offers ballast in turbulent markets.

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For individual investors, the biggest risk is not missing the next big theme — it is chasing it without a disciplined game plan.

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Jayanth Nanjappa
Chief Strategist
Robustness Finserve Private Limited

The key is to find the right mix, neither overly diversified nor recklessly concentrated. Allocations must shift dynamically, overweighting cyclical themes in recovery phases, defensive ones when clouds gather, and raising the debt quotient (perhaps 20–35%) when valuations look frothy.

By combining the explosive power of thematic equities with the steady discipline of debt, investors can create a portfolio that is greater than the sum of its parts — one that can navigate the

unpredictable rhythms of the market.

Investing in the stock market can be a daunting task, especially when it comes to navigating multiple themes. For most individual investors, trying to go it alone is like stepping onto a cricket pitch without proper training or equipment. Time is a precious commodity, and expertise is often limited, which can lead to emotional decisions that sabotage even the best-laid plans.

Rebalancing a portfolio in a tax-efficient manner while keeping track of various themes can be overwhelming. This is where hybrid fund-of-funds come into play, offering a professional approach to investing. Managed by experienced teams with access to research models and macroeconomic insights, these funds combine high-conviction thematic equities with a stabilizing debt component. They adjust their strategy, ramping up aggression when opportunities arise and retreating when markets become overheated. The result is participation in exciting themes and improved risk-adjusted returns over the long term.

For individual investors seeking to capitalize on thematic trends without taking on excessive risk, these hybrid funds offer a relatively stable foundation. By leveraging the expertise of seasoned professionals and adopting a disciplined approach, investors can navigate the complexities of the market with confidence and achieve their long-term wealth creation goals.

Disclaimer: Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully. The NAVs of the schemes may go up or down depending upon the factors and forces affecting the securities market including the fluctuations in the interest rates. The past performance of the mutual funds is not necessarily indicative of future performance of the schemes. The Mutual Fund is not guaranteeing or assuring any dividend under any of the schemes and the same is subject to the availability and adequacy of distributable surplus. Investors are requested to review the prospectus carefully and obtain expert professional advice with regard to specific legal, tax and financial implications of the investment/participation in the scheme.